heels, not sure quite how it would turn out or how it would express its beliefs or share its technology, but it opened my eyes all the same.

Some people have a talent for friendship. It might be one of the things that marks out leadership. I used to have it, but I'm not so sure nowadays. After I'd been back in Melbourne a while, I started making plans to attend the University of Melbourne, to study maths and physics. I met a great guy there called Daniel Mathews, who was bright, with a kind of electric flair for fresh thinking and political judgement. I met some people who shared my political instincts, and of course my friends and colleagues understood the power of the Internet, but Dan was the only person I met who shared both of my great passions. He really understood the opportunity that new technology offered to activists. He once wrote a long poem called 'If You Saw', which I posted on my blog, liking the nice, idealistic sweep of the lines:

> *The ordinary people, not –ese and not –ism,*
> *They stood there and shrugged – I'm just a human! –*
> *And spilled over borders, and greeted their neighbours,*
> *And played with their children, and looked to the future,*
> *And cared not for great things, but just to continue.*

Nobody should be immune from the hope embedded in those lines. I was living in eastern Melbourne at the time, with my son, who went to Box Hill High School, and I was burying myself in maths problems. There had already been a coming together, in my mind, between activism and technology, and I had founded a fledgling organisation called leaks.org in 1999. Like many a fledgling, it was starved of nourishment and didn't go anywhere, but it grew in my head and so did the name. But, as I was saying, the future seemed to lie for me in new friends and new kinds of problems. There was something beautiful in the truth revealed by maths – something perfect and just, and I grew experienced in the study of that, not just the problems themselves but the entire moral scope of quantum mechanics.

I finally started at university in 2003. It felt overdue, like something I had been working towards for a long time. Melbourne University is the second oldest in Australia, an avowedly secular institution run by the state. The campus is in Parkville, a leafy part of town with many Victorian terraces,